Chapter One

The lighthouse keeper had counted the ships for forty years, and in all that time he had never once seen the same vessel twice. Each morning he wrote the names in a ledger bound in green cloth, and each evening he read the names back to himself as other men might read a prayer. The ledger was nearly full now, and he wondered whether he should order another or whether the sea would simply stop sending ships when the last page was written.

His daughter visited on Sundays, bringing bread and the week of newspapers

that the village had already finished with. She would sit on the stone step while he climbed to polish the great lens, and she would call up to him the headlines she thought he would like, which were mostly about weather and never about war. When the lamp flickered and the shadows crept along the wall of the tower, she knew it was time to walk back along the cliff path before the dark caught her.

There was a story in the village that the keeper could name a ship from the sound of its engine alone, and that he had once turned a trawler away from the rocks by shouting its name into the fog. He denied it when asked, but he

denied it in the manner of a man who would rather the story be told than forgotten, and so the children went on telling it.

Chapter Two

The winter that the ledger ran out was the coldest anyone could remember. Ice formed on the inside of the lantern room and the keeper spent his nights scraping it from the glass with the edge of a brass rule. The ships came anyway, fewer of them and slower, their lights smeared by the frost into long yellow streaks that he followed with his eyes until they vanished past the

headland and left him alone again with the sound of the wind.

On the last night of the year a steamer passed so close that he could hear the men singing on her deck, and he stood with his pen above the final empty line and could not bring himself to write. He told his daughter afterwards that he had not caught the name, but she had seen the lights too and she knew that the keeper did not miss names. She bought him a new ledger in the spring, bound in blue this time, and he filled the first page before the week was out.

Chapter Three

The new ledger outlasted him, as he had known it would. When the lighthouse was finally automated the engineers found both books on the shelf beside the clockwork, the green one full and the blue one not, and they sent them to the daughter with a polite letter that she kept folded inside the back cover. On quiet evenings she still reads the names aloud, slowly, in the order he wrote them down, so that for a little while the ships are counted once again.